Psychology -3-

17 May 1949

(b)(3)

INFORMATION FOR: [redacted]
Room 2101 G Building

SUBJECT: Communist "confession" techniques

1. With reference request of 20 April 1949, there is no body of reliable information on techniques employed to obtain "confessions".

2. Evidence is inferential but is sufficient in quantity to be convincing and to enable firm opinion as to the [redacted].

3. Of the techniques considered, direct physical torture, dialectic persuasion and attack by drugs were considered and rejected. Psycho-surgery, electric and drug shock were also investigated and rejected in the light of evidence and reports from files and by observers.

4. It is the opinion of OSI that the incongruities of the confessions and anomalous behavior of defendants can only be explained by the application of procedure which has resulted in a basic change in the functional organization of the defendant's mind with associated change in character structure.

5. Without presenting the detailed evidence, suffice it to say that all points toward the application of techniques of hypnosis and/or hypno-analysis, the confessions being elicited either by virtue of post hypnotic suggestion with resultant trance state, or by means of accelerated psycho analytic techniques combined with post hypnotic behavior.

6. The feasibility of accomplishing the foregoing has been established in psychiatric and clinical practice and the usefulness of this method may be extended to the following areas:

a. Interrogation
b. Counter measures to interrogation
c. Directed activity
d. Preparation of agents for covert activity

7. Methods are being studied and evaluated by OSI, and fuller report will be forthcoming.

[redacted]

(b)(3)

METHODS OF INDUCTION

1. Passes

   a. Old method

   b. Requires much time

   c. Requires cooperative subject.

2. Contact

   Passes with contact with body.

3. Sense Stimulation

   (Overstimulation) - fixation methods.

   a. Fatigue of sense of sight - especially by having subject stare at bright object held above line of vision.

   b. Bright objects, coins, keys, etc.

   c. Soft music, monotonous poetry

   d. Cooperation required.

4. Suggestion - as of sleep.

   a. Comfort

   b. Relaxation

   c. Suggestion or command to sleep

   d. Cooperation required

5. Waking (suggestive) Hypnosis - combination of 3 and 4.

6. Drug Hypnosis

   a. Rapid

   b. Works when other methods fail

   c. Trance same as that of foregoing

d. Technique

(1) Narcosis induced by gradual admin. drug.

(2) Hypnosis induced by verbal suggestion during light narcosis preparatory for analysis and hypnosis.

(3) Routine investigation history, mental state, etc.

(4) Regression and eliciting of remote events, especially of childhood to establish content and dynamics of ideation and orientation.

(5) After salient factors determining patient's orientation are determined - new associations are created to obtain new orientation to reality.

(6) Repeat daily.

(7) Post-hypnotic state re-inforced in waking patient by explanation, persuasion and re-education.

(8) Since transference phenomena are common, it is important to choose an object which can be made suitable and is adequate for environmental contact.

1. Charges- Sabotage of Russian Industrial Program
   Dissemination of propaganda of anti-communistic nature
   Disclosing military secrets to fascist military forces.
   Attempting to introduce Bourgeois socialist doctrine.
2. Relative Importance of Activity of Defendants.

   Key political and military figures.
   Key government technicians and managers.

3. Political significance of trials.

   Evidence of tightening of controls of Politburo.
   Effort of Stalin to eliminate all opposition.
   (Reference to poisoning of relative of Stalin's)
   Also some reference by historians to almost frenzied period of S- reflected in purge activity.
   Stalin did not repeat mistake of Trotsky exile.

4. Behavior of Defendants

I. Precise arrangement of Courtroom.
Defendants in row facing Prosecutor.

Orderly and timed procedure of trials.

No interruption or cross examination as in U.S.

II. Evidence of guilt and confession presented by each defendant as called upon by Vichinsky.

A. Testimony of each defendant recited as a well rehearsed and just short of repetition from memory recital of the events leading up to and the nature of defendants guilt.

B. Further confession of having been guilty of plotting against the soviet state and therefore against the people.

C. Prompting from the Prosecutor at times when the defendants faltered. Indication that defendants waited for the prpmpting and at all times looked directly at P. One defendant .... promulgator of soviet legal codes faltered and broke down at one point and ixxxrsat down. Was allowed to continue his testimony later.

Not many instances of this kind of breakdown. Generally testimony was given haltingly but steadily.

5/ Newspaper Accounts

I. Verbatim newspaper accounts of trial are in tone of guilt already an established fact and purpose of trial merely a chance for the defendants to publicly proclaim their infidelty

AN ANALYSIS OF CONFESSIONS IN RUSSIAN TRIALS

1. ORIENTATION:

Since the notorious Moscow trials of 1937, overt Russian judicial procedure has been noteworthy for the dramatic trials in which the defendants have exhibited anomalous and incomprehensible behavior and confessions. Characteristics and manner of the defendants, and formulation and delivery of the confessions, have been so similar in a large number of cases as to suggest factitious origin. Most noteworthy and incredible has been the recent "confession" of His Eminence Cardinal Josef Mindszenty while on trial in the People's Court of Hungary for treason.

The evident incongruities prompted this study, the purposes of which were to analyze a number of instances of trials and confessions to investigate:

a. The overall pattern of the arrest, trial, and performances of the members of the cast.

b. The occurrence of any consistent or recurring details of procedure or behavior.

c. If the foregoing formed a congruent pattern, the method by which the result was achieved.

2. PROCEDURE:

Source material was widely diverse and reference is made to significant items. It became apparent at the outset of the study that the style, context and manner of delivery of the "confessions" were such as to be inexplicable unless there had been a reorganization and reorientation of the minds of the confessees. There is adequate historical experience to establish that basic changes in the functional organization of the human mind cannot be brought about by the traditional methods of physical torture--these at the most, achieve a reluctant, temporary yielding and, moreover, leave their mark upon the victim.

Newer or more subtle techniques had, therefore, to be considered for the working hypothesis. Among the recognized methods are:

a. Psychosurgery: a surgical separation of the frontal lobesof the brain.

b. Shock method:
   (1) electrical
   (2) drug: metrazol, cannabis indica, insulin, cocaine.

c. Psychoanalytic methods
   (1) psychoanalysis
   (2) narco-analysis and synthesis
   (3) hypno-analysis and synthesis

d. Combinations of the foregoing.

In order to develop group patterns of behavior and interactions certain significant elements were tabulated, Chart 1.